



UKIYO-E

The Japanese art form of ukiyo-e, which means “pictures of the floating world,” flourished between the 17th and 19th centuries. These prints depicted everyday life in Edo Japan, such as this market street scene.



▲ KABUKI

Kabuki was a type of theatrical performance with extravagant costumes, makeup, wigs, and masks. Originally women played all the roles, but they were soon banned from the stage and performances became all-male.

Edo Japan

Japan's Edo period was a time of peace, when art and culture flourished and the economy boomed following centuries of war and unrest. Even when the country closed itself off from the wider world, Japan continued to thrive, and many innovations that developed during this time, from *ukiyo-e* art to sumo wrestling, are still part of Japan's modern cultural identity.

The Edo period began in 1603 when Tokugawa Ieyasu moved his capital to Edo (modern-day Tokyo) after reunifying Japan and becoming shogun (see p.74). The Great Peace followed—a marked change after years of warfare between competing *daimyo* (feudal lords).

Right from the start, the shogun was extremely wary of foreign influences. Christianity was rising rapidly in popularity, spurred on by Portuguese missionaries, and this was seen as a threat to the Buddhist way

of life. Christianity was banned in 1614 and its followers were tortured, executed, or both.

Shortly after, in 1635, *sakoku* came into effect—a policy that isolated Japan from the rest of the world. Limited trade with a small number of nations continued, but hardly anyone was allowed in or out of the country. This policy remained in place until the Meiji Restoration (see pp.168–169) in 1868, which brought the Tokugawa shogunate and the Edo period to an end.